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Healthcare in Korea for Foreigners

Korea has one of the world's best healthcare systems — affordable, fast and high quality. Here's how to navigate it as a foreigner.

Types of Medical Facilities



Clinic

의원 (Uiwon)

Small neighborhood clinics — for colds, minor injuries, prescriptions. Fast, cheap (~₩3,000–8,000 with NHI). Always try here first.



Hospital

병원 (Byeongwon)

Mid-size hospitals (30–100 beds). For more serious conditions. Specialist doctors available. Some English spoken.



General Hospital

종합병원

Large multi-department hospitals. Best for complex conditions. Usually have international clinics for foreigners.



Pharmacy

약국 (Yakguk)

Green cross sign. Open late, even 24h in some areas. Pharmacist will recommend OTC medicine. No appointment needed.



Dental Clinic

치과 (Chigwa)

Excellent quality, affordable even without insurance. Cleaning, fillings and routine work covered partly by NHI.



Eye Clinic

안과 (Angwa)

Glasses, contacts and laser surgery (LASIK) — Korea is world-famous for affordable, high-quality eye surgery.



National Health Insurance (NHI)

Korea's National Health Insurance (국민건강보험, NHI) covers all legal residents — including foreigners staying 6+ months. It significantly reduces medical costs (typically covering 60–80% of fees).

1

Automatic enrollment (employed)

If you work for a Korean company, your employer automatically enrolls you and pays 50% of your premium. You pay the other 50% from your salary. No action needed.

2

Self-enrollment (self-employed / long stay)

Visit your nearest NHIS (국민건강보험공단) office or apply at nhis.or.kr. Bring ARC + passport + proof of address. Takes about 30 minutes.

3

Pay your monthly premium

Monthly premium for foreigners: ~₩79,000–150,000 depending on income. Can be paid via bank auto-transfer (자동이체) — set it up and forget it.

4

Use your insurance card at clinics

Show your ARC at the reception — your NHI is linked to it. You pay only the copay portion (usually ₩2,000–10,000 for a basic clinic visit).



NHI is worth it: A clinic visit without NHI: ₩30,000–60,000. With NHI: ₩3,000–8,000. Hospital stay: 80% covered. It pays for itself after one or two doctor visits per year.



Medical Costs With vs Without Insurance

TREATMENT	WITHOUT NHI	WITH NHI
Clinic visit (cold, flu)	₩30,000–50,000	₩3,000–8,000
Prescription (3 days)	₩15,000–30,000	₩3,000–7,000
Blood test	₩50,000–100,000	₩10,000–20,000
X-ray	₩50,000–80,000	₩10,000–20,000
Dental cleaning	₩60,000–80,000	₩20,000–30,000
Hospital admission (per day)	₩200,000+	₩40,000–80,000



Foreigner-Friendly Hospitals in Seoul

INTERNATIONAL CLINICS & ENGLISH-SPEAKING HOSPITALS

- **Severance Hospital** (신촌) — International Health Care Center, full English service
- **Samsung Medical Center** (강남) — International Clinic, multi-language support
- **Asan Medical Center** (강동) — Large international department
- **Seoul National University Hospital** — International Healthcare Center
- **Korea University Anam Hospital** — English-speaking doctors
- Search "**foreigner friendly hospital**" on Naver Maps for clinics near you



Using a Pharmacy

HOW PHARMACIES WORK

- Look for the green cross (약국) sign — pharmacies are everywhere
- You need a doctor's prescription (처방전, cheo-bang-jeon) for most medicines
- OTC medications (감기약 cold medicine, 두통약 headache medicine, 소화제 digestive) are available without prescription
- Tell the pharmacist your symptoms — they'll recommend what to buy
- 24-hour pharmacies exist in major areas — search 24시 약국 on Naver Maps



Emergency Numbers



Ambulance / Fire

119

Call 119 for medical emergencies and fire. Available 24/7. Some operators speak basic English. Give your location in Korean if possible.



Police

112

Call 112 for police assistance. Interpretation service available in multiple languages — tell them your language when connected.

Foreign Resident Support

1345

Korea Immigration Information Center. English/Chinese/Japanese support. For non-emergency help with medical, legal, or living issues as a foreigner.

Healthcare Korean Phrases

여기가 아파요.	<i>yeo-gi-ga a-pa-yo.</i>	It hurts here. (pointing)
열이 있어요.	<i>yeor-i i-sseo-yo.</i>	I have a fever.
알레르기가 있어요.	<i>al-le-reo-gi-ga i-sseo-yo.</i>	I have an allergy.
처방전 주세요.	<i>cheo-bang-jeon ju-se-yo.</i>	Please give me a prescription.
영어 할 수 있는 의사 있어요?	<i>yeong-eo hal su it-neun ui-sa i-sseo-yo?</i>	Is there a doctor who speaks English?
두통약 있어요?	<i>du-tong-nyak i-sseo-yo?</i>	Do you have headache medicine?
건강보험 있어요.	<i>geon-gang-bo-heom i-sseo-yo.</i>	I have health insurance.

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